

Day 50 — TNPSC Group 2A Study Material

Part A – General Studies: Thirukkural: Significance as Secular Literature, Universal Values, and Philosophical Content

READING MATERIAL

Thirukkural (by Thiruvalluvar) is treated as a major standalone topic given its weight in the syllabus and the density of real exam evidence. Covers its secular/universal character, translation history, scholarly commentaries, and several specific philosophical couplets actually tested in past papers.

Q: Real exam: Who described Thirukkural as 'a compilation of the sublime, pure human thoughts', and who, based on that description, referred to Thirukkural as the Tamils' sacred book?

A: M. Ariel made the 'sublime, pure human thoughts' description. Mahatma Gandhi, drawing on that characterization, referred to Thirukkural as the Tamils' sacred book — confirmed by a real exam question. This underlines Thirukkural's SECULAR character: it's revered like scripture without being tied to any single religion.

Q: Real exam: Who translated Thirukkural into French, and what's the common confusion with the German translation?

A: M. Ariel translated Thirukkural into FRENCH — confirmed by a real exam question. The German translation was actually done by Karl Graul, NOT Ariel — a separate real exam question tested 'translated into German — Ariel' as a FALSE statement, confirming this distinction. (The most famous ENGLISH translation is by G.U. Pope.)

Q: What is structurally distinctive about Thirukkural's first and last couplets, in terms of the Tamil alphabet?

A: Thirukkural's first couplet begins with the letter 'அ' (the first letter of the Tamil alphabet), and a later couplet/the text's structure is associated with the letter 'ஊ' (a final-position letter) — symbolically spanning the entire Tamil alphabet, reinforcing its claim to comprehensive, universal scope.

Q: Real exam: Match these scholarly commentaries/works on Thirukkural to their authors.

A: Thirukkural Uraivalam — Thandapani Thesigar. Thirukkural Nunporul Malai — Karirathina Kavirayar. Thirukkural Araichi Pathippu — Ki.Va. Jeganathan. Vazhum Valluvam — Va.Se. Kulanthai Samy — all four confirmed via a real exam's match-the-following question, illustrating the depth of scholarly commentary tradition built around the text.

Q: Real exam: How did Perarignar Anna (C.N. Annadurai) promote Thirukkural specifically during his administration, and what claim about him is FALSE?

A: TRUE measures: the Secretariat nameboard 'Tamilaga Arasu Thalaimai Seiyalagam' was put up at Fort St. George for the first time under his rule, AND steps were taken to write Thirukkural verses on Tamil Nadu Government buses. FALSE claim (tested and rejected by a real exam): that he REMOVED 'Satyameva Jayate' from the government motto — he did not actually do this.

Q: Real exam: According to Valluvar, what is described as the 'weapon to destroy the arrogance of foes'?

A: Wealth — confirmed by a real exam question (a specific Kural on porul/wealth's practical power, not heroism, fortification, or force alone).

Q: Real exam: What does a specific Pope-translated Kural couplet say about envy?

A: 'Nor wealth nor virtue does that man possess, who feels at others' wealth and prosperity distress' (approximate English rendering) — confirmed by a real exam question testing comprehension of this specific G.U. Pope-translated couplet on the vice of envy.

Q: Real exam: Whose duties does Thirukkural implicitly teach, per a specific tested chapter?

A: Women's duties — confirmed by a real exam question (referring to a specific chapter on household/wifely conduct within the text's broader ethical framework).

MOCK TEST (WITH ANSWERS)

1. Who described Thirukkural as 'a compilation of the sublime, pure human thoughts', a description Mahatma Gandhi drew on to call it the Tamils' sacred book?

A. G.U. Pope

B. M. Ariel ✓

C. Karl Graul

D. Arignar Anna

Explanation: M. Ariel. [medium, question-bank-2025]

2. Who translated Thirukkural into French?

- A. Karl Graul
- B. G.U. Pope
- C. M. Ariel ✓**
- D. Taylor

Explanation: M. Ariel. [medium, question-bank-2026]

3. Who translated Thirukkural into German (NOT Ariel, a common false pairing)?

- A. Karl Graul ✓**
- B. M. Ariel
- C. G.U. Pope
- D. Wilson

Explanation: Karl Graul. [hard, question-bank-2025]

4. Which scholar wrote 'Thirukkural Uraivalam'?

- A. Karirathina Kavirayar
- B. Ki.Va. Jeganathan
- C. Va.Se. Kulanthai Samy
- D. Thandapani Thesigar ✓**

Explanation: Thandapani Thesigar. [hard, question-bank-2025]

5. Which scholar wrote 'Vazhum Valluvam'?

- A. Va.Se. Kulanthai Samy ✓**
- B. Ki.Va. Jeganathan
- C. Karirathina Kavirayar
- D. Thandapani Thesigar

Explanation: Va.Se. Kulanthai Samy. [hard, question-bank-2025]

6. Real exam: Which of the following did Perarignar Anna's administration actually do, related to Thirukkural and Tamil promotion?

- A. Removed 'Satyameva Jayate' from the government motto
- B. Wrote Thirukkural verses on Tamil Nadu Government buses ✓**
- C. Banned non-Tamil names for government buildings
- D. Made Thirukkural a compulsory school subject

Explanation: Wrote Thirukkural verses on TN Government buses. [hard, question-bank-2026]

7. The Secretariat nameboard 'Tamilaga Arasu Thalaimai Seiyalagam' was put up for the first time, under Perarignar Anna's rule, at:

- A. The Madras High Court
- B. Fort St. George ✓**
- C. Rajaji Hall
- D. The Tamil Nadu Assembly

Explanation: Fort St. George. [hard, question-bank-2026]

8. According to Valluvar, what is described as the weapon to destroy the arrogance of foes?

- A. Heroism
- B. Force
- C. Fort
- D. Wealth ✓**

Explanation: Wealth. [medium, question-bank-2024]

9. A specific Thirukkural chapter (tested in a real exam) implicitly teaches the duties of:

- A. Men
- B. Women ✓**
- C. Citizens
- D. The King

Explanation: Women. [hard, question-bank-2025]

Part B – Aptitude & Mental Ability: Percentage

READING MATERIAL

Percentage is 1 of 10 named Aptitude sub-skills. TNPSC's percentage questions are built from a handful of recurring shapes — successive discounts, reverse percentage ('20% of $x = 50$, find x '), percentage of a mixture, and percentage of a time period — recognize the shape first, then compute.

Q: Method — successive percentage discounts: A TV was sold for ₹14,400 after successive discounts of 10% and 20%. What was its original (market) price?

A: Successive discounts don't add (it's NOT a flat 30% off) — apply them one after another. If the market price is P : $P \times 0.90 \times 0.80 = 14,400 \rightarrow P \times 0.72 = 14,400 \rightarrow P = 14,400 / 0.72 = ₹20,000$.

Q: Method — percentage of a mixture (the parts must add to 100%): An alloy is 30% copper and 40% zinc, rest nickel. Find the nickel in 20 kg of the alloy.

A: Nickel % = $100 - 30 - 40 = 30\%$. Nickel amount = 30% of 20 kg = 6 kg. The key step is realizing the percentages must total 100% — nickel is whatever's left over, not a number given directly.

Q: Method — reverse percentage ('find the whole, given a percentage of it'): If 20% of $x = 50$, find x .

A: 20% of $x = 50 \rightarrow 0.20 \times x = 50 \rightarrow x = 50 / 0.20 = 250$. Reverse-percentage questions give you the part and the percentage, and ask for the whole — divide, don't multiply.

Q: Method — percentage of a decimal/small number: Find 0.75% of 40 kg.

A: $0.75\% = 0.0075$. $0.0075 \times 40 = 0.3$ kg. Common mistake: treating '0.75%' as '0.75' (i.e. 75%) instead of converting the decimal percentage properly — always convert to a decimal fraction first (divide by 100) before multiplying.

Q: Method — percentage of a time period: What percentage of a day is 10 hours?

A: A day = 24 hours. $10/24 \times 100 = 41.67\%$.

Q: Method — percentage of a fraction: What percent of $2/7$ is $1/35$?

A: Set up: $x\% \text{ of } (2/7) = 1/35 \rightarrow x/100 \times 2/7 = 1/35 \rightarrow x = (1/35) \times (7/2) \times 100 = (7/70) \times 100 = 10\%$.

Q: Method — sum of two independent percentage-of-number terms: Find the value of 28% of 450 + 45% of 280.

A: 28% of 450 = 126. 45% of 280 = 126. Sum = $126 + 126 = 252$. (A nice coincidence both terms equal 126 here — don't expect that in general, just add the two percentage values separately.)

Q: Method — percentage greater than 100% (the result is bigger than the original number): Find 280% of 3,940.

A: $280\% = 2.80$. $2.80 \times 3,940 = 11,032$. Percentages over 100% just mean the result is larger than the base number — the calculation method doesn't change.

MOCK TEST (WITH ANSWERS)

1. A mobile phone was sold for ₹10,200 after successive discounts of 15% and 20%. What was its original price?

- A. ₹14,500
- B. ₹15,000 ✓**
- C. ₹15,500
- D. ₹16,000

Explanation: $P \times 0.85 \times 0.80 = 10,200 \rightarrow P \times 0.68 = 10,200 \rightarrow P = 15,000$. [medium, authored]

2. An alloy is 25% tin and 35% lead, the rest is copper. Find the copper in 40 kg of the alloy.

- A. 10 kg
- B. 14 kg
- C. 16 kg ✓**
- D. 20 kg

Explanation: Copper % = $100 - 25 - 35 = 40\%$. 40% of 40 kg = 16 kg. [easy, authored]

3. If 35% of $y = 91$, find y .

- A. 230
- B. 250
- C. 260 ✓**

D. 240

Explanation: $y = 91 / 0.35 = 260$. [easy, authored]

4. Find 1.25% of 80 kg.

A. 1 kg ✓

B. 10 kg

C. 0.1 kg

D. 12.5 kg

Explanation: $1.25\% = 0.0125$. $0.0125 \times 80 = 1$ kg. [easy, authored]

5. What percentage of a day is 6 hours?

A. 20%

B. 25% ✓

C. 30%

D. 16.67%

Explanation: $6/24 \times 100 = 25\%$. [easy, authored]

6. What percent of $3/8$ is $3/40$?

A. 10%

B. 15%

C. 20% ✓

D. 12%

Explanation: $x\%$ of $(3/8) = 3/40$, so $x/100 = (3/40) \div (3/8) = (3/40) \times (8/3) = 1/5$, giving $x = 20\%$. [medium, authored]

7. Find the value of 32% of 350 + 18% of 200.

A. 148 ✓

B. 138

C. 150

D. 146

Explanation: 32% of 350 = 112. 18% of 200 = 36. Sum = 148. [medium, authored]

8. Find 320% of 2,500.

A. 7,500

B. 8,000 ✓

C. 8,500

D. 9,000

Explanation: $320\% = 3.2$. $3.2 \times 2,500 = 8,000$. [easy, authored]

9. A quantity is first increased by 20%, then decreased by 20%. What is the net percentage change?

A. No change

B. 4% decrease ✓

C. 4% increase

D. 20% decrease

Explanation: Net change after +20% then -20% is always a decrease of $(20 \times 20)/100 = 4\%$ — increasing and then decreasing by the same percentage never cancels out, because the second change applies to a different (larger) base. [hard, authored]

10. The price of an item increases from ₹250 to ₹300. What is the percentage increase?

A. 15%

B. 20% ✓

C. 25%

D. 30%

Explanation: Increase = 50. Percentage increase = $(50/250) \times 100 = 20\%$. [easy, authored]

Part C – General English: Prose: "The Last Stone Carver" — Sigrun Srivastav

READING MATERIAL

A story about an old master stone carver who, expecting to find his usual helper Gopal in the workshop, instead discovers his young servant Salim secretly carving a statue's eyes and eyebrows — and, after his initial shock fades, embraces Salim's hidden talent and dream of becoming a sculptor.

Q: Who did the old man expect to find in the workshop, and what sound first alerted him that someone was there?

A: He expected to see Gopal (his usual helper). The sound of CHISELLING reached his ears from the workshop.

Q: Who did the old man actually find working in the workshop, and what was that person's relationship to him?

A: Salim — who was the old man's SERVANT, not a family member or formal apprentice.

Q: What was the old man's first emotional reaction on seeing Salim working, and which tool was notably NOT in Salim's hands?

A: Shock (followed later by anger, which then faded). A brush was NOT among the tools mentioned in Salim's hands — he was working with sculptor's tools like the hammer and chisel, not a brush.

Q: What part of the statue was Salim working on, and where had he secretly practised, and for how long?

A: He was working on the statue's EYES AND EYEBROWS. He had secretly practised at the QUARRY, for 2 YEARS.

Q: What did Salim express as his life's dream, and how did the old man ultimately react to this confession?

A: Salim's dream was to become a SCULPTOR. After his initial shock and anger faded, the old man felt RELIEVED AND HAPPY, and ultimately ACCEPTED AND PRAISED Salim rather than punishing or rejecting him.

Q: What does the old man's line "You have it in your hands and heart" suggest about Salim?

A: That Salim possesses NATURAL TALENT for stone carving — not that he stole or copied his skill, but that genuine ability and passion are both present in him.

MOCK TEST (WITH ANSWERS)

1. Who did the old man expect to see in the workshop?

- A. Ramu
- B. Salim
- C. Gopal ✓**
- D. Shankar

Explanation: Gopal. [medium, web-research]

2. What sound reached the old man's ears from the workshop?

- A. Music
- B. Rain
- C. Chiselling ✓**
- D. Whispering

Explanation: Chiselling. [easy, web-research]

3. What emotion did the old man feel first when he saw Salim working?

- A. Happiness
- B. Shock ✓**
- C. Pride
- D. Joy

Explanation: Shock. [medium, web-research]

4. What tool was NOT mentioned in Salim's hands?

- A. Hammer
- B. Brush ✓**
- C. Chisel
- D. None — all were mentioned

Explanation: Brush. [hard, web-research]

5. Where had Salim secretly practised stone carving for two years?

- A. School
- B. Workshop
- C. Temple
- D. Quarry ✓**

Explanation: Quarry. [medium, web-research]

6. What part of the statue was Salim working on when discovered?

- A. Ears
- B. Chin
- C. Eyes & Eyebrows ✓**
- D. Feet

Explanation: Eyes & Eyebrows. [medium, web-research]

7. What was Salim's relationship to the old man?

- A. Son
- B. Friend
- C. Servant ✓**
- D. Apprentice

Explanation: Servant. [medium, web-research]

8. What did Salim express as his life's dream?

- A. To become a priest
- B. To be a carpenter
- C. To be a sculptor ✓**
- D. To be a teacher

Explanation: To be a sculptor. [easy, web-research]

9. How did the old man ultimately react to Salim's confession?

- A. Rejected him
- B. Punished him
- C. Accepted and praised him ✓**
- D. Ignored him

Explanation: Accepted and praised him. [medium, web-research]

10. The old man's line "You have it in your hands and heart" suggests that:

- A. Salim stole the talent from someone
- B. Salim needs much more practice
- C. Salim is naturally talented ✓**
- D. Salim copied another carver's work

Explanation: Salim is naturally talented. [hard, web-research]